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Hausa theatre in Niger

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The Troupe Amadou Dan Bassa of the Maison des Jeunes, Zinder

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The rehearsals I observed by Zinder's Troupe Amadou Dan Bassa in March 1981 were in the final stages of preparation for the National Festival in April. They had been rehearsing their play, Talala Mai Kaman Sake,⁽⁸⁴⁾ for about two months previous to their March 9th performance at the regional competitions in Tanout, where they were chosen to represent the Zinder Département at the national event. I observed one performance in Zinder before the preliminary competitions, two performances in Tanout, and their final performance for the National Festival in Diffa, as well as rehearsals between these performances.

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In this final month of preparations, more elaborate costumes were made, two cloth backdrops were painted, and a flat was built with a functional door for Talala's fancy house. None of these, however, was brought to or used in rehearsals. Many of the rehearsals had actors substituting in others' roles, both because of frequent absences and in order to make everyone familiar with other roles, should substitutes be needed. This indeed happened: the actor playing the judge in the final scene was unable to travel to Diffa for the

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festival and a replacement had to be found three days before the troupe left Zinder.

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Some of the changes introduced during these last weeks of rehearsal included the following: (⁸⁵) ■121

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Material Not Relevant

--The name for Talala's orphaned niece was changed from Salamatu to Rabi [both are common Hausa women's names], because the actress's mother, whose name was Salamatu, had died and she did not wish to be called by her late mother's name, even in a play. (⁸⁶)

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--Talala's scene (3) at home with his two wives was clarified at several points. The troupe discussed his entrance, what he should bring his wife, what time of day it was. They decided he should bring his first wife a leg of lamb and not money, and that she should be crocheting as he entered. Alternatively, they discussed having her wash dishes, but decided against that because the scene was to be in the living room (where dishes were not appropriate) and his wife was of a status that she should not be seen washing dishes. Crocheting was felt to be most appropriate to the wife's character and it is something that the actress does well. Six or seven men in the troupe participated in this discussion, including Yazi Dogo who played Talala. The women were not present at the rehearsal at the time; they arrived later but were not consulted.(3/18/81)

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--The young wife, Sululu, who leaves for her parents' house during this scene (3) because Talala has neglected her, had been critiqued by the jury at the regional competition; Yazi Dogo reported that they felt it should be clearer why she was leaving. Subsequently, over several days, the troupe rehearsed a longer dialogue between the two wives before Talala's entrance, and the first wife added a longer explanation to Talala about why the younger one had gone off.(3/30 and 3/31/81)

--The jury at Tanout had also docked points from the troupe's total for being over the ninety minute time limit. Consequently the troupe timed all the scenes carefully, without interruption, but it was generally agreed that the first scene was the one that had to be cut. The essentials of the scene were delineated as settling the fight between Musa and Zangina [which brings out a discussion of wasan nangi, the joking relationships between different groups of people, a point about national unity], and the explanations to the visitors from abroad about the functions of Niger's samariyas. The number of visitors ■122 was reduced from four to three, and their series of questions distilled into three basic ones.(3/18/81)

--One of the older members of the troupe was given instructions to face the audience, to slow down his speech and to gesture more expansively. Kailou Bako demonstrated for him what they wanted him to do. At another rehearsal, his lines were stressed as one of the key points of the Funeral scene (2) (see below). (3/26/81)

--A woman's role was added to the scene (6) in which the destitute widows decide they must sell their dowries because Talala has failed to give them their due share of the inheritance. Instead of the widows talking over the need to sell their marriage goods, as they had in the Tanout performances, the character Alhajiya was introduced to bargain for them. This required a means of calling her; respectable widows would not be able to leave the house. So they called their son into the scene to fetch Alhajiya. While waiting for her arrival, the widows continued their dialogue about needing money, then greeted Alhajiya and asked her if she would buy the blankets and pots they showed her.

The new actress as Alhajiya, after one attempt at acting out the scene from the description, was given instructions by Oumarou Naïnou in how she was to bargain; she must be polite, even friendly, but unwilling to buy anything, except at a very low price. The animateur of the Maison des Jeunes, who did not act in this play, then demonstrated the role for her, in caricature, to the amusement of the troupe. The women repeated their scene. Then Oumarou took Alhajiya's role, with the animateur and another young man as the two widows. As the men imitated women in gross caricature, the humor softened the critique of the new actress, yet it made their point clear. At the same time it strengthened the troupe's sense of solidarity through mutual laughter, a shared joke. (3/30/81)

--Later in the same scene (6), when Talala visits the widows, his niece Rabi's refusal to speak to him was emphasized. In the March performances, she left as soon as the women heard him arrive outside. In the rehearsal changes, her exit was delayed until he came all the way into the room where the women were sitting and had begun to greet him. [This emphasized ■ 123 her rudeness in not speaking to him]. (3/31/81)

--Several of the actresses were critiqued repeatedly for mumbling, looking at the floor while speaking, covering their faces, fidgeting; on different occasions the men satirized this overly modest behavior (kunya) by imitating it. (3/30, 3/31 and 4/1/81).

--Just before the troupe's departure for the Diffa Festival, and just after Yazi Dogo returned from a week's absence in Niamey, the troupe discussed the important points of the play and the problem of the time limit. They all agreed that the first two scenes, the longest in the play, needed to be shortened. Yazi, Kailou, and Abdou Louché outlined the key points, with a few comments by the others, as follows:

Scene 1: The nangi relationships between the different peoples [the chain of ethnic groups linked in these traditional relationship strengthens national unity].

The purpose of the samariyas [as explained to the foreign visitors].

[Both of these instructive points are contained in the speeches of Mai Samari, played by Kailou].

Scene 2: The old malam refusing to give an appropriate sadaka (offering) at the Funeral.

The three questions posed by Talala's friend [played by Abdou Louché]: negligence, corruption, and lack of conscience [by those officials people trust].

[The discussion passed over the next four scenes which portray the corruptions of Talala after being entrusted with his dead brother's fortune].

Scene 7: The malam's pronouncement of Talala's moral failings at court. (4/1/81)

These points form the core of the play, the purpose and background message against which the story of ■ 124 Talala neglecting his brother's family for his own aggrandizement plays itself out.

The title, Talala Mai Kaman Sake, is a proverb, literally "tethering (with a long rope) like release." R.C. Abraham translates the proverb: "it's a case of giving him a rope to hang himself with!" (Dictionary of the Hausa Language, London: University of London Press, 1962), p. 845.

In his Introduction to the performance of the play at the Diffa Festival, the Inspecteur de la Jeunesse for the Département of Zinder made the following explanation of the title:

La chèvre qu'on attache au bout d'une longue corde se croit à liberté jusqu'au moment où tenter de dépasser son ère de p[unknown]aturage elle se sent retenue. Telle est dans sa traduction la plus simple le sens de "Talala Mai Kaman Sake." Notre personnage est à l'image de cette chèvre. Devant la confiance de la famille du défunt, Talala s'est octroyé une certaine liberté qui va jusqu'à l'abus du détrimement. Mais comme nous l'avons dit plus haut: chaque liberté a sa fin. La réaction des victimes à bout de patience ne suffit pas attendre. C'est alors seulement que notre personnage compris, mais un peu tard, toute la signification du proverbe, "Talala Mai Kaman Sake."

The dates after each paragraph refer to my rehearsal notes for these changes, some of which occurred over several days, but I have tried to note the most important points of change. These rehearsals took place between the Zinder regional competitions in Tanout, 5-11 March, and the National Festival in Diffa, 6-14 April 1981.

Personal communication from Yazi Dogo, Zinder, 10 September 1981.

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